

This image is from *Hellblazer: Pandemonium*, marking the return of original series writer Jamie Delano.

HELLBLAZER

In the cinema

The mistakes of ignoring the source material

The film had been mooted for several years but it only became a reality in 2004 when director Francis Lawrence became attached to it. The problem with it was the fact that Hollywood decided it would be more appealing to viewers if they moved the setting from England to America and changed Constantine from an English to an American character. The problem was that, once they removed what made the comic different, then all they were left with was a generic horror action movie in the vein of *Angel Heart*. None of the supporting cast survived the transition from comics to the big screen. Keanu Reeves as Constantine was miscast, although Tilda Swinton as Gabriel was a canny choice and the film did bring Shia LaBoeuf to the world's attention.

Despite its critical reception, especially among comic readers, it did do reasonably well at the box office, taking $230 million. In fact, Reeves even talked about a sequel for a while and is quoted as saying: "I would do that in a second," but then he added, "They're producers, so they have to be optimistic. It's not up to me, man. It's up to whomever wants to provide the resources to make that movie. I don't think Warner Bros. is going to do it. I don't think it makes fiscal sense for them, because they don't feel it will make money." Director Lawrence stated that he would return, but only in a producing capacity. However, things have been very quiet since 2008 and so it is unlikely that we shall ever see a follow-up to *Constantine*.







Constantine, is available to buy on DVD and Blu-ray from £16.99

Even though the character of Constantine has become most associated with London, he actually hails from the northern city of Liverpool.

have a charitable bone in his body, or only does good when he's forced into it. Quite the opposite, in fact. He's risked his life – and afterlife – for the greater good on countless occasions. Okay, so as often as not he'd fuck it up spectacularly, often with even more horrific consequences. But the point is, he *tries*. He doesn't just shrug off the horror he sees in the world around him, and try to ignore it like we do. He bloody well does something about it. Someone much smarter than me (I wish I could remember who it was! Paul Jenkins maybe?) once described Constantine as a hedonist whose conscience keeps getting in the way, and I think that sums him up pretty well. And, of course, the fact that we're even discussing him in this way suggests he's a lot more fully rounded a character than you find in many comics. He has a life, not an 'origin story'. He's flawed and contradictory and often self-defeating but he struggles on, screaming his defiance into the face of an uncaring universe. In other words, a human being."

> "The potential for new stories are endless. He's like Doctor Who in that way" (Tim Bradstreet)

After the newer names route, Vertigo turned to one of the writers who had been there before the imprint even had a name. Peter Milligan was a contemporary of Grant Morrison, who had won plaudits with his work on *Animal Man*, *Shade The Changing Man* and *Enigma* for DC. Milligan has always been able to meld bizarre supernatural happenings with a very British sensibility and his run on *Hellblazer* shows a man with renewed vigour for his work. Artistically, he has even managed to re-energise artist Simon Bisley, who has produced his best efforts in years in tandem with Milligan.

It is obvious that he understands what makes Constantine work, and he told us recently why he thinks the title has managed to continue after all these years. "The series continues to engage and entertain because Constantine is such a complex character. He's the perfect flawed and fucked-up everyman for our times. Even after all this time, it seems that each new writer finds new things he wants to say, through the old mage."

In 2009, Vertigo published *Dark Entries*, an original graphic novel and the first in its Vertigo Crime sub-imprint. Described as a 'John Constantine Novel', it was written by bestselling crime author Ian (*Rebus*) Rankin. A 214-page black-and-white story that threw Constantine into the world of reality TV with just the sort of blackly humorous feel that *Hellblazer* has made its trademark.

While its sales are lower than they have been, thanks mainly to the vagaries of a changing comic market, *Hellblazer* continues to be a regular presence in an industry filled with fly-by-night characters and companies. There are over 40 collections of *Hellblazer* material currently available, so there's little danger of the trench-coated spiv disappearing any time soon. So let's raise a glass to the difficult bastard and we'll leave the last word to artist Tim Bradstreet, whose covers graced *Hellblazer* for an impressive 81 issues.

"Has it been 25 years? Goodness. Well I believe that when Vertigo first launched their imprint they likely had no idea they'd still be pumping out issues of a regular series for Constantine in 2010… The appeal for the reading audience, to me, is staggering. There is such a large and rich history for the character now that the potential for new and original stories are endless. He's kind of like *Doctor Who* in that way. You could set Constantine down about anywhere, from a nameless pub to the Isle of Gruinard (Anthrax Island) and you've got the potential for a great adventure. Plus you have writers the world over who would love a crack at writing the guy. I remember Denise Mina once said she'd 'eat her own guts to write *Hellblazer*'. Well you can't get much more exuberant than that!… The reading audience includes a lot of those professionals and the appeal is obvious. In an industry dominated by superheroes, there is one non-superhero character that has stood alone for 25 years, and that's John Constantine: Hellblazer."

Collected editions of *Hellblazer* are published by Titan Comics in the UK.